

Birth of Hangeul & Simple Vowels

drjay-ed · Hunminjeongeum

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Hello! Hangeul is one of the most scientific writing systems in the world. Today, let's discover how it was born and unlock the secret of its eight simple vowels.

Before we had our own script

Long ago, Koreans had no script of their own, so they borrowed complex Chinese characters. Hanja was so hard that most common people could not read at all.

King Sejong's compassion

Seeing his people suffer because they could not read, King Sejong was deeply moved. 'Out of compassion, I create twenty-eight new letters.'

1443: Hunminjeongeum is created

Finally, in 1443, Hunminjeongeum was born — a script anyone could learn. The wise learned it in a morning; anyone, within ten days.

Heaven · Earth · Human

Hangeul's vowels are modeled on three elements of the universe: heaven, earth, and human. Heaven is a round dot, earth a flat horizontal line, and human an upright vertical line.

vertical + dot → 亅 / 冫

Add the heaven dot to the right of the human line and you get the bright sound ' 亅 ', the rising sun in the east. Put it on the left, and you get the dark sound ' 冫 ', the setting sun in the west.

horizontal + dot $\rightarrow$ $\perp$ / $\top$

Place the dot above the earth line and you get ' $\perp$ '; below it, ' $\top$ '. Rising above is bright; sinking below is dark.

Vowel Harmony

So bright vowels pair with bright, and dark vowels with dark. This beautiful order is called vowel harmony.

8 simple vowels

Now let's make some sounds. Korean has eight simple vowels. Unlike English, the secret is to keep your mouth shape perfectly still. Let's say them together. ㅏ, ㅑ, ㅓ, ㅕ, ㅗ, ㅛ, ㅜ, ㅠ.

ㅏ / ㅑ — open vertical, lips flat

First, 'ㅏ' and 'ㅑ'. For both, drop your jaw to open wide and keep your lips flat. Open wider for 'ㅏ', a bit narrower for 'ㅑ'.

ㅊ / ㅊ — round your lips

For 'ㅊ' and 'ㅊ', round your lips like holding a straw and push them forward. 'ㅊ' is a little bigger, 'ㅊ' smaller and tighter.

— / | — **stretch lips sideways**

For '—', stretch your lips flat sideways like a forced smile. For '|', pull them even wider so your teeth almost show.

ㅏ / ㅑ — open mid, tongue forward

Finally, 'ㅏ' and 'ㅑ'. Open your mouth moderately with the tongue forward.

In modern Korean, the two sounds are almost the same.

Check in the mirror

Check in a mirror! Your lips should round only for 'ㄷ' and 'ㅌ' — never for 'ㅍ' or 'ㅁ'.

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Practice today's vowels in front of a mirror every day. Subscribe and like for more fun Hangeul adventures. See you next time!